Diversity Statement

Waseem Raza, PhD | Assistant Professor in Data Science | Seton Hall University

What diversity means to me in computer science and a university community

In computer science, diversity includes more than the demographic characteristics of the people who enter a classroom. It encompasses different educational pathways, prior exposure to programming, mathematical preparation, life experiences, cultures, languages, perspectives, and the kinds of problems students believe computing can address. These differences influence who feels that they belong in CS and data science, whose questions are heard, and which needs technological systems are designed to serve.

I see a university community as most effective when individuals with different backgrounds can participate in the same high academic standards while receiving transparent expectations, equitable opportunities, and respect. For computing in particular, diversity improves the questions we ask about data and algorithms: whom a dataset represents, where a model performs poorly, how an interface is understood, and what assumptions a team has overlooked. Inclusion is therefore connected to both educational opportunity and the quality of technical work.

Inclusive instruction grounded in preparation and evidence

My experience teaching Computer Programming, Communication Systems, and Wireless Communication, supporting technical laboratories, and mentoring research students has reinforced the importance of recognizing different starting points. A student who has never used a development environment should still have a realistic path to the same learning objectives as someone with years of coding experience.

I would use explicit prerequisite reviews, accessible course materials, small formative assessments, reproducible starter code, and multiple ways for students to demonstrate understanding through explanations, implementation, and evaluation. Structured team roles and consistent rubrics would help prevent the most confident students from monopolizing project work. Office hours, timely feedback, and opportunities to revise mistakes would communicate that uncertainty and learning are normal parts of rigorous computing education.

Data science provides particularly useful opportunities for discussing fairness and representation. For example, students could inspect whether an activity-recognition model degrades for a participant missing from the training distribution, or whether operational data omit important contexts. They would learn to examine sample composition, metric choice, error disparities, data privacy, and model limitations. The aim would be careful technical reasoning and respectful discussion, not prescribing a single perspective.

Mentorship, belonging and university service

I would seek to make research participation available to students with varied backgrounds, not only those who already have advanced programming skills or professional connections. Entry points such as dataset documentation, visualization, baseline reproduction, test writing, and literature review can give newer researchers substantive responsibility. As students grow, they can move toward experimental design, paper writing, presentation, and mentoring their peers.

I would also support advising and student recruitment by explaining clearly what computing disciplines involve, how students can prepare, and what opportunities exist across data science, computer science, and engineering. Collaboration with colleagues and student-support programs would help students navigate challenges without lowering academic expectations.

Seton Hall's commitment to a vibrant, inclusive community, ethical development, and service resonates with my view that faculty should combine intellectual rigor with respect and responsibility. I would contribute by making expectations transparent, encouraging thoughtful disagreement, evaluating students fairly, and ensuring that students with different experiences have meaningful opportunities to learn, collaborate, and succeed.